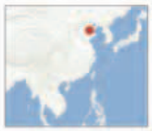
SECOND OPIUM WAR

ATTACK ON THE DAGU FORTS



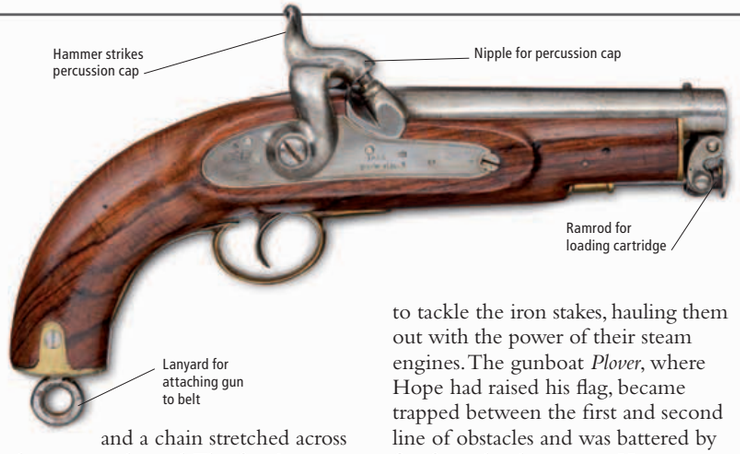
Date June 25, 1859
Forces British: 2 gun vessels, 9 gunboats; Chinese: shore batteries
Losses British: 4 ships; Chinese: unknown

Location Peiho River, northern China

On October 8, 1856, the Chinese authorities stopped and searched a merchant vessel, *Arrow*, that was later alleged to have been flying the British flag. On this flimsy pretext Britain launched a punitive action against China, soon abetted by France. On May 20, 1858, a dozen British and French gunboats bombarded the Dagu forts at the entrance to Peiho River, placing Tientsin and Beijing at their mercy. The Chinese were forced to sign another humiliating peace treaty.

But the Qing government did not implement the treaty in full. The next year, the British sent another naval force to Peiho River, under Rear Admiral James Hope. This time the Chinese were better prepared. They had blocked the river in front of the forts with three lines of obstacles, including iron stakes in the riverbed and a chain stretched across the narrow channel. The forts' guns were protected by thick earth ramparts.

The night before the assault on the forts, Hope sent a party to blow up the obstacles in the river, but it had little success. In the morning, the nine gunboats and two larger gun vessels headed into the river mouth on the flood tide. Under the guns of the forts only a few hundred yards away, they had to tackle the iron stakes, hauling them out with the power of their steam engines. The gunboat *Plover*, where Hope had raised his flag, became trapped between the first and second line of obstacles and was battered by fire from the shore guns. Hope was among the wounded as the boat became a slaughterhouse, only nine of her 40 crew still functioning. The gun vessel *Cormorant* and gunboats *Kestrel* and *Lee* were also sunk; an attempt by marines to storm the forts was a costly failure. The surviving boats withdrew in the evening. This was an unusual reverse for the Royal Navy which was avenged the following year when an Anglo-French force sacked Beijing.



Percussion pistol
Percussion pistols shared the same design as flintlocks, but had a different firing mechanism. The hammer struck a cap containg an explosive that lit the charge in the barrel.



Bombardment of Canton
In December 1857, during the Second Opium War, British and French warships bombarded, and then occupied, the port of Canton.

> OCCUPATION WOULD GO FURTHER TO PROCLAIM OUR POWER AND ACCOMPLISH OUR ENDS.
>
> **LORD PALMERSTON**, AUTHORIZING THE OCCUPATION OF BEIJING

ANGLO-EGYPTIAN WAR

BOMBARDMENT OF ALEXANDRIA



Date July 11–13, 1882
Forces Britain: 15 ships; Egyptians: shore batteries
Losses None

Location
Alexandria, Egypt

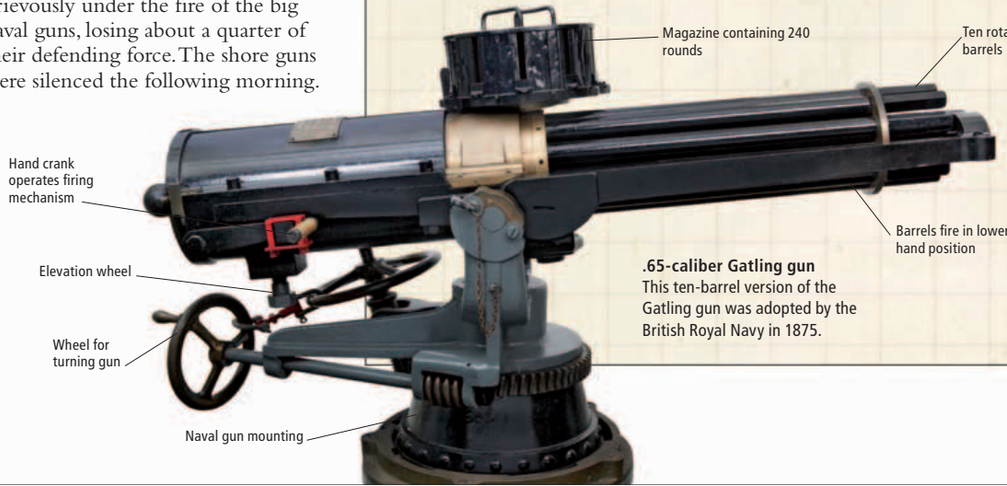
In 1882 a government took power in Egypt opposed to Anglo-French dominance of the country. In June there were riots in Alexandria and many foreign residents took refuge on British and French warships offshore. The Egyptians set about reinforcing the forts defending the port. British admiral Sir Frederick Seymour interpreted this as a hostile act and issued an ultimatum. The French dissociated themselves, leaving the Royal Navy to fight alone. The British had a varied force of ironclads, including the giant turret ship *Inflexible*, the most powerful warship afloat, whose captain was the future admiral of the fleet John Fisher. Seymour chose the center-battery ironclad *Invincible* as his flagship.

The British opened fire on the Egyptian forts at 7:00 a.m. on July 11. The shore guns returned fire and the action continued for the next ten and a half hours. *Invincible* and the corvette *Penelope*, which advanced into the harbor, both took hits, as did *Inflexible*, but the ships' armor provided good protection and casualties were light. The Egyptians, by contrast, suffered grievously under the fire of the big naval guns, losing about a quarter of their defending force. The shore guns were silenced the following morning.

WEAPONS AND TECHNOLOGY

GATLING GUN

Patented by American inventor Richard Jordan Gatling in 1862, the Gatling gun was an early machine gun that found favor with the British Royal Navy. It had multiple barrels rotated by a hand-operated crank. As each barrel came round a cartridge automatically dropped into place and the gun fired. By this method the gun could achieve an effective rate of fire of 400 rounds a minute. The Royal Navy adopted the Gatling gun as an ideal weapon to repel boarders. It was never employed in this role, but Gatling guns were fired against Egyptian forts during the bombardment of Alexandria in 1882, and Naval Brigades used them on land in various colonial wars. They were superceded by Gardner guns in the late 1880s.



.65-caliber Gatling gun
This ten-barrel version of the Gatling gun was adopted by the British Royal Navy in 1875.